and stiffly explained to the IT rep what he already knew: how I'd found the directory traversal problem, how I'd reported it, how I hadn't received any response until now. I finished up with, "I really appreciate you telling me. I hope I didn't cause any problems."

"Not at all," the IT rep said, and then asked what I did for a living.

"Nothing really," I said.

He asked whether I was looking for a job and I said, "During the school year, I'm pretty busy, but I've got a lot of vacation and the summers are free."

That's when the lightbulb went off, and he realized that he was dealing with a teenager. "Well, kid," he said, "you've got my contact. Be sure and get in touch when you turn eighteen. Now pass me along to that nice lady I spoke to."

I handed the phone to my anxious mother and she took it back with her into the kitchen, which was filling up with smoke. Dinner was burnt, but I'm guessing the IT rep said enough complimentary things about me that any punishment I was imagining went out the window.